Story Planning

Working title: _____
Draft: _____ Date: _____
Kaylee Renaud

For a story that does not exist yet — or one that is refusing to work. Answer badly first.

1 THE FORM

Decide this early — it changes every other answer on the sheet

☐ feature ☐ TV pilot — half hour ☐ TV pilot — hour ☐ limited series ☐ short film ☐ short story ☐ novel ☐ play ☐ comic ☐ audio
SOMETHING ELSE — NAME IT

Why this form and not the one next to it? What can it do that the others cannot?

Target length, and the closest thing to it that already exists:

2 THE SEED

Do not make it sound good yet. Making it sound good is how ideas get lost.

The image, line, or moment that will not leave me alone:

Where it came from — and what I am actually trying to work out by writing it:

Now say what it is about *badly*, in one ugly sentence. Leave the ugly sentence on the page.

3 THE LADDER

Same story at five altitudes. If two rungs disagree, that is the note.

	WRITTEN OUT	DOES IT MATCH THE RUNG ABOVE?
One sentence		
One paragraph		
The question it asks		
The argument it makes		
The promise of the genre — what does someone expect walking in?		

4 WHOSE STORY IS IT?

The test: take each one out. Whose story is still standing?

CHARACTER	WANTS (SAYS OUT LOUD)	NEEDS (DOES NOT KNOW)	WOULD NEVER DO	DOES IT ANYWAY WHEN...	WHAT IT COSTS

5 THE SHAPE

Draw it before you name it. The name is only useful if the drawing came first.

DRAW THE SHAPE OF THE STORY — A LINE, A SPIRAL, A BRAID, A CIRCLE, A STAIRCASE

Tick anything that fits what you drew. Cross out what nearly fits. If nothing does, the sheet is wrong and the drawing is right — describe it in your own words instead.

☐ three-act ☐ kishōtenketsu ☐ jo-ha-kyū ☐ two-hander / duel
☐ rival accounts ☐ braided ensemble ☐ circular / return ☐ odyssey
☐ slice of life ☐ mosaic of vignettes ☐ frame story ☐ reverse chronology
☐ daisy chain ☐ nested ☐ one continuous day ☐ procedural ☐ drifting

IN MY OWN WORDS

6 TURNS, BY WHAT CANNOT BE UNDONE

Not act breaks — irreversibility. That is the only structural test that survives every form.

If nothing became impossible to undo, it was an event, not a turn. A story with two real turns and six events is the most common thing wrong with a draft.

#	ROUGHLY WHERE	WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT CAN NEVER BE UNDONE AFTER THIS	WHO CAUSED IT

Which turn am I least sure of — and what am I avoiding by leaving it vague?

Which turn happens *to* the protagonist rather than *because* of them? Is that a problem?

7 PROMISES & PAYOFFS

The first tenth of anything is a contract

THE PROMISE MADE EARLY	WHERE IT IS PAID	PAID · SUBVERTED · DROPPED

8 THE ENDING, WRITTEN NOW

Even if it changes. Especially if it changes.

The last image or last line, written today:

The second-to-last beat — the one that makes the last one land:

Does the opening promise this ending? If not, which of the two is wrong — and which am I more attached to?

9 THE WORLD AND ITS RULES

	THE RULE	WHAT IT COSTS TO BREAK IT	WHO BREAKS IT, AND WHEN
Rule 1			
Rule 2			
Rule 3			

What does this world let me say that the real one will not?

What is ordinary here that would be strange to us — and how do I show it without explaining it?

10 WHAT THE STORY BELIEVES

Theme, without being embarrassed about it

What the story believes, in plain words:

The strongest possible case for the opposite:

Who carries that belief — and do they know they are carrying it?

Who carries *that* — and honestly, are they a straw man?

11 THE DESIGN COLUMN

You dress people for a living. Put it in the outline, not the prep.

Wardrobe is the fastest character document there is — it says want, class, era, self-image and self-deception before a line of dialogue. Writing it now will change the scenes you plan.

CHARACTER	FIRST LOOK	LAST LOOK	WHAT CHANGED — AND THE MOMENT THE AUDIENCE NOTICES

The palette of the whole thing — fill each box, then name it

The one image this whole story is built around:

What does the audience see before anyone says anything?

12 WHAT I NEED TO KNOW

Research, but only the kind that changes a scene

WHAT I NEED TO KNOW	WHO OR WHAT WOULD TELL ME	BY WHEN	✓

13 THE LADDER OF SCENES

One row per scene or sequence. The last column is the honest one.

Fill the middle columns fast and the last column slowly. Any row where the honest answer to "why can it not be cut" is "because I like it" is a row to look at twice.

#	WHERE / WHEN	WHO	WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT CHANGES	WHY IT CANNOT BE CUT

14 WHAT I ALREADY KNOW IS BROKEN

Park it here. Do not fix it now — naming it is the whole job today.

15 THE NEXT FOURTEEN DAYS

A plan that ends here is a daydream with a table

I WILL...	BY (DATE)	WHO KNOWS I SAID SO